water & sanitation
Department:
Water and Sanitation
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

NATIONAL INTEGRATED WATER INFORMATION SYSTEM

Monthly National Drought Bulletin

Drought classification (D0–D4), SPI/SPEI, cascade, outlook and affected settlements.

Generated	02 Nov 2026, 10:33 (SAST)
Data as of	02 Nov 2026
Area	South Africa (national)
Period	12M
Issued by	Department of Water and Sanitation, Republic of South Africa

Drought Status Monitoring

Live · as of Aug 2026 | Data to Dec 2025

Drought Class
8 % of area in D1–D4 · worst class on ≥ 20 % of the area (SPI-6, Aug...

No drought

No drought

SPI-3 (area-weighted mean)
Aug 2026

−0.83

D1 Moderate Drought

SPI-6 (area-weighted mean)
Aug 2026

0.44 No drought

SPEI-12 (area-weighted mean)
Aug 2026

1.07 No drought

VCI
Dec 2025

87 % Excellent

Data to Dec 2025

Soil Moisture Anomaly
surface, Dec 2025 vs 2015–2025

13 %

Data to Dec 2025

SSI-3 (modelled runoff)
Aug 2026, gamma fit 2000–2025

0.49 No drought

Dam Storage

—

Dam storage is withheld: failed plausibility: frozen since Dec 2021 in all 52 districts (national 17 715...

SGI

—

Latest valid SGI is Aug 2024 (more than 90 days old); the newer 10_1 SGI is withheld (not an index of a...

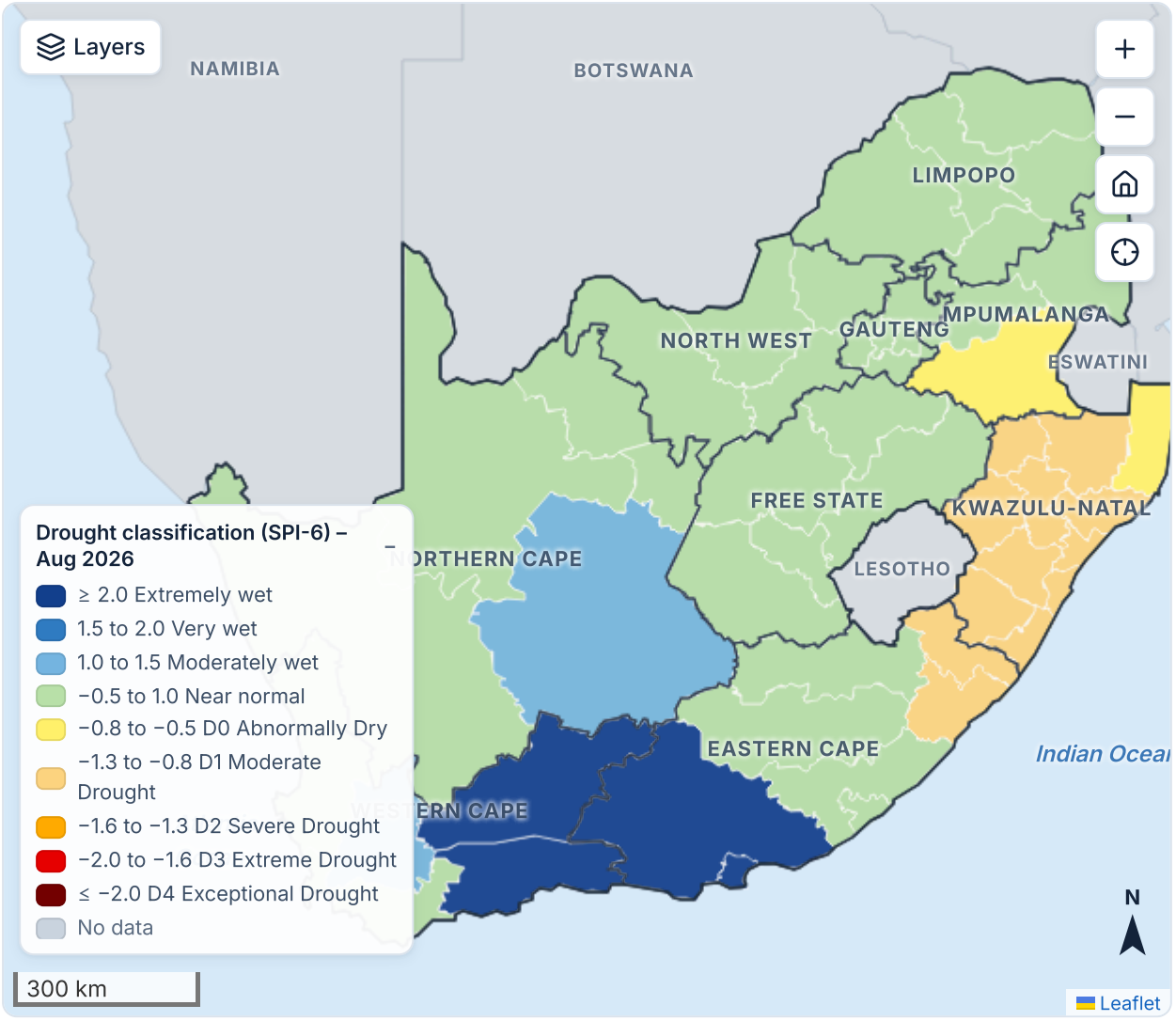
Settlements at Risk

—

No settlement register in the database

Drought Status Map – South Africa

● Live · as of Aug 2026



Drought Cascade (Current Status)

● Live · as of Aug 2026 | Data to Dec 2025

1. Precipitation deficit (SPI-6)

SPI-6 0.44

Aug 2026

No drought

↓

2. Soil moisture (surface, anomaly)

+13 % vs 2015–2025

No agreed soil-moisture anomaly classes yet: the anomaly is shown without a class

Data to Dec 2025

↓

3. Vegetation (VHI %)

VHI 93 %

Data to Dec 2025

Excellent

↓

4. Streamflow (SSI-3 of district flow)

SSI-3 0.66

Aug 2026

No drought

↓

5. Reservoir (dam storage % FSC)

—

Dam storage is withheld: failed plausibility: frozen since Dec 2021 in all 52 districts (national 17 715 Mm³ every month) and implausible swings before (national 421 Mm³ in Jun 2021, 16 617 Mm³ in Aug 2021). The reservoir table 8_1 fails too: 51 of 52 districts hold the same storage (251 997 542.57 m³ = 100 % FSC, level 1 200 m, 52.5 km² water area) on every day from January 2000 to October 2026; only Vhembe varies

↓

6. Groundwater (level anomaly)

—

No area-weighted value for this scope (Groundwater (level anomaly))

↓

7. Socio-economic (settlements at risk)

—

No settlement / population data in the database

Most Affected Provinces / Catchments

● Live · as of Aug 2026

Provinces | Catchments

#	Province	SPI-6 (area-weighted mean)	Drought class	Area affected	Confidence	Last update
1	KwaZulu-Natal	−0.93	D1 Moderate Drought	85%	—	01 Aug 202
2	Mpumalanga	−0.18	D0 Abnormally Dry	0%	—	01 Aug 202
3	Gauteng	0.06	No drought	0%	—	01 Aug 202
4	Free State	0.12	No drought	0%	—	01 Aug 202
5	North West	0.27	No drought	0%	—	01 Aug 202
6	Limpopo	0.30	No drought	0%	—	01 Aug 202
7	Eastern Cape	0.41	No drought	14%	—	01 Aug 202
8	Northern Cape	0.81	No drought	0%	—	01 Aug 202
9	Western Cape	1.45	No drought	0%	—	01 Aug 202

Not available: Confidence *(No forecast / ensemble data to estimate confidence)*

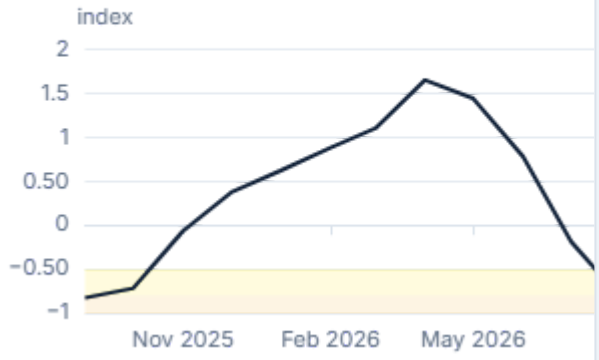
SPI – Standardised Precipitation Index

Area-weighted mean of district SPI-3; complete months only.

● Live · as of Aug 2026

3-Month | 1-Month | 6-Month | 12-Month

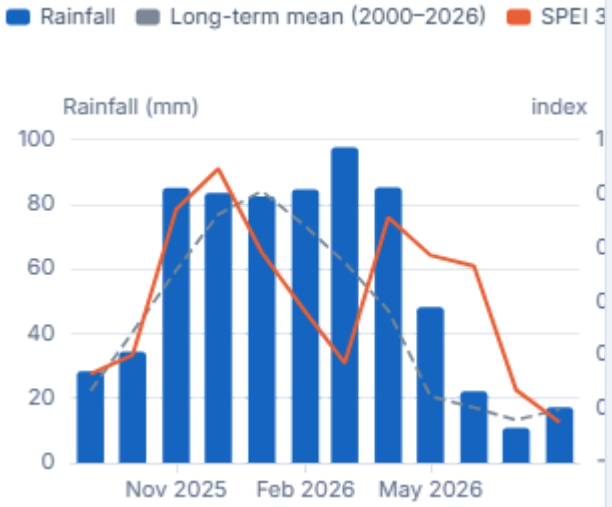
SPI 3 – Short Term Agricultural Drought



Rainfall & SPEI Trends

Normal: 2000–2026 mean (data start in 2000). Complete months only.

● Live · as of Aug 2026



Dam Storage, Inflow and Outflow

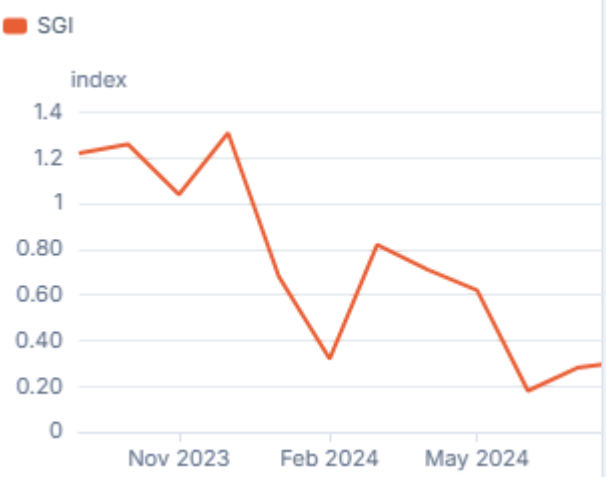
Not yet available

Dam storage is not available: failed plausibility: frozen since Dec 2021 in all 52 districts (national 17 715 Mm³ every month) and implausible swings before (national 421 Mm³ in Jun 2021, 16 617 Mm³ in Aug 2021)

Groundwater Levels & SGI

Values after Aug 2024 repeat Aug 2024 and are withheld.

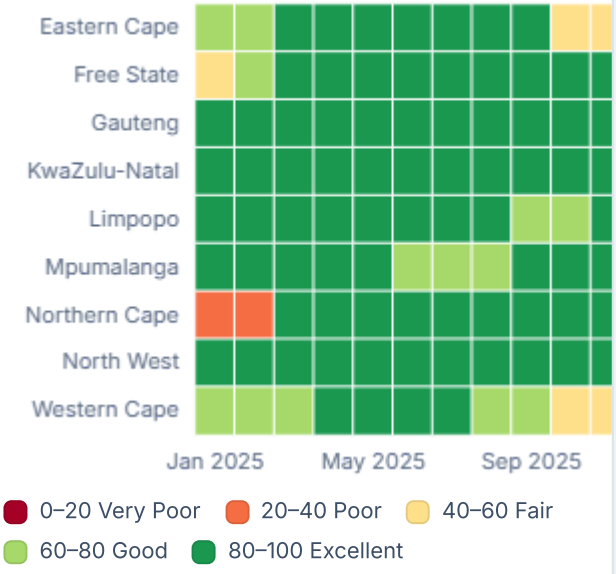
● Live · as of Aug 2024 | Data to Aug 2024



Not available: Mean borehole level (m bgl) *(Borehole water level is withheld: values (−0.18 … +0.20) are not depths below ground)*

Vegetation Condition (VCI) by Province

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025



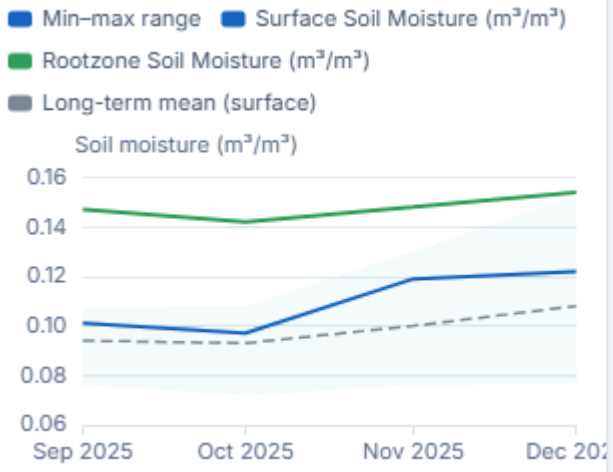
Soil Moisture (Surface & Root-zone)

Range and mean per calendar month over 2015–2025 (the satellite soil-moisture recor...

Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

Data ends Dec 2025: only part of the selected period has values.

Show last available 12 months (Jan 2025 – Dec 2025)

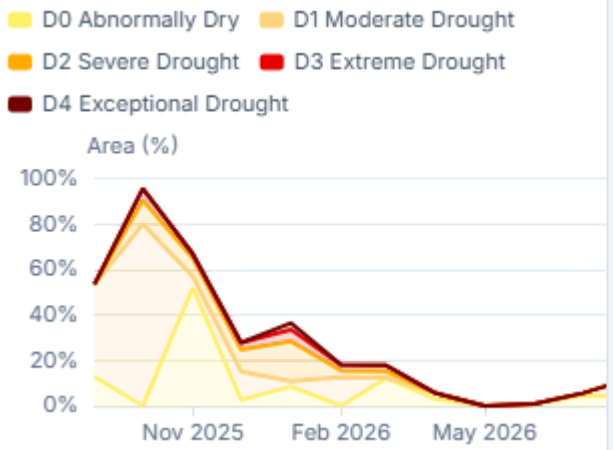


National Drought Trend (Area %)

Share of the scope's area whose district SPI-6 falls in each class.

Live · as of Aug 2026

SPI-6 | SPI-3 | SPI-12



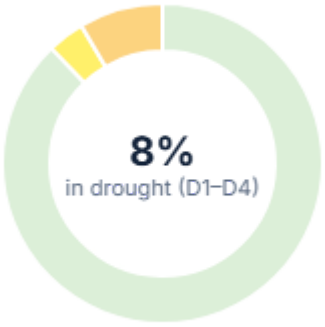
Reservoir Storage vs Drought Index

Not yet available

Storage by dam size needs per-dam data

Drought Severity Distribution

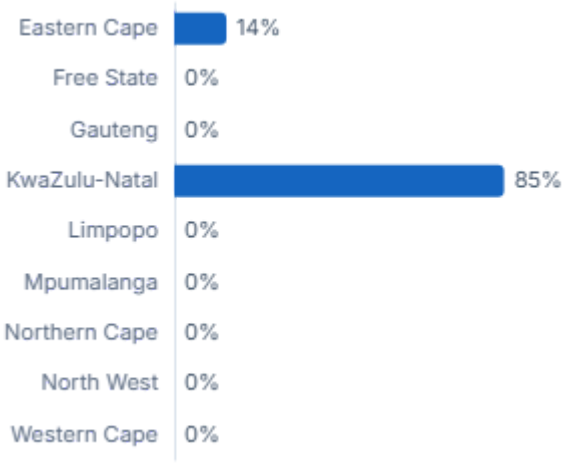
● Live · as of Aug 2026



No drought	1 073 153	88%
D0 Abnormally Dry	45 775	4%
D1 Moderate Drought	103 508	8%
D2 Severe Drought	0	0%
D3 Extreme Drought	0	0%
D4 Exceptional Drought	0	0%

Drought-affected Area by Province

● Live · as of Aug 2026



Drought Outlook (Next 3 Months)

Computing this forecast...

The district SPI-3 forecasts are being computed; try again in a few minutes. This panel checks again in a minute.

- Most exposed now: **KwaZulu-Natal and Mpumalanga**.

Drought Early Warning (Next 3 Months)

● Live · as of Aug 2026

Indicator	Current status	Forecast (3 months)	Confidence
SPI-3	D1 Moderate Drought	No drought	75%
SPI-6	No drought	D0 Abnormally Dry	37%
SPEI-3	No drought	No drought	93%
Area in drought (D1–D4)	8 % of the area in D1–D4	47 % (more area in drought)	95%

Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) / SARIMA (order by AIC) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Top 10 Most Affected Municipalities

● Live · as of Aug 2026

#	Municipality	Province	SPI-6	Drought class	Population affected	Water supply risk
1	iLembe	KZN	−1.24	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
2	O.R. Tambo	EC	−1.18	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
3	eThekwini	KZN	−1.17	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
4	Alfred Nzo	EC	−1.15	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
5	Ugu	KZN	−1.08	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
6	Harry Gwala	KZN	−1.07	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
7	uMzinyathi	KZN	−1.05	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
8	uMgungundlovu	KZN	−1.03	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
9	uThukela	KZN	−1.03	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—
10	King Cetshwayo	KZN	−1.02	D1 Moderate Drought	—	—

Not available: Population affected *(No population or water-supply data in the database)*; Water supply risk *(No population or water-supply data in the database)*

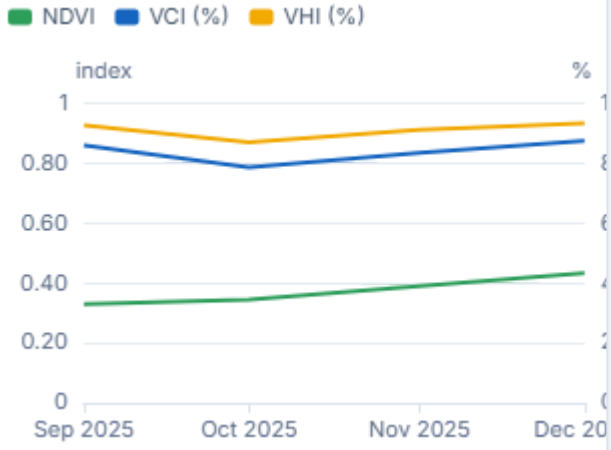
Vegetation Condition (NDVI / VCI / VHI)

satellite_remote_sensing (single vegetation source for the drought and vegetation...

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

Data ends Dec 2025: only part of the selected period has values.

Show last available 12 months (Jan 2025 – Dec 2025)



Population in Drought-affected Municipalities

Not yet available

No population / settlement data in the database

Water Restrictions by Province

Not yet available

Water restrictions are not in the database

Data Source Status

● Live · as of Sep 2026 | Some sources stale

Source	Feed	Status	La
meteorological_drought_master	daily, 52 districts	Online	06
satellite_remote_sensing	monthly, 52 districts	Delayed	01
hydrological_drought_master	monthly, 52 districts	Delayed	01
6.1_core_rainfall_variables_master	daily, 52 districts	Online	06
6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master	monthly, 52 districts	Online	01

Scroll sideways for more columns →

Database variables

Every table and column of the national database for this page, with the database's own names and units.

Spec coverage

● Live · as of Sep 2026

Drought: 4 tables · 54 columns · 33 live · 14 withheld · 7 duplicates Show every column →

Live columns are plotted below. Withheld columns failed a check or hold placeholder values (reason given); duplicates repeat another column.

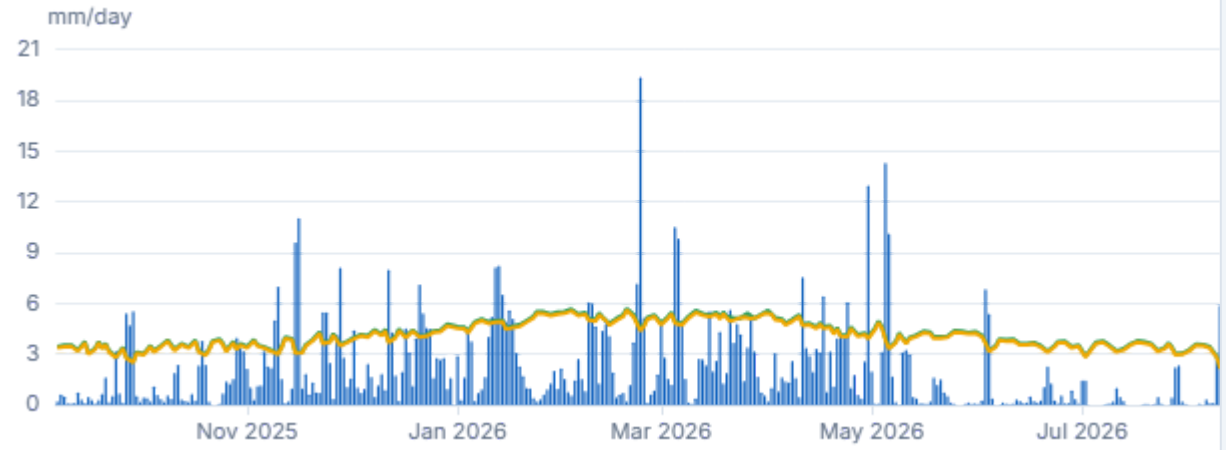
Meteorological Drought §3.1 `meteorological_drought_master` 17 live · 3 withheld · 5 duplicates

data to Sep 2026

Meteorological Drought · Daily Rainfall / PET / ET_0 (mm/day) · §3.1

● Live · as of Sep 2026

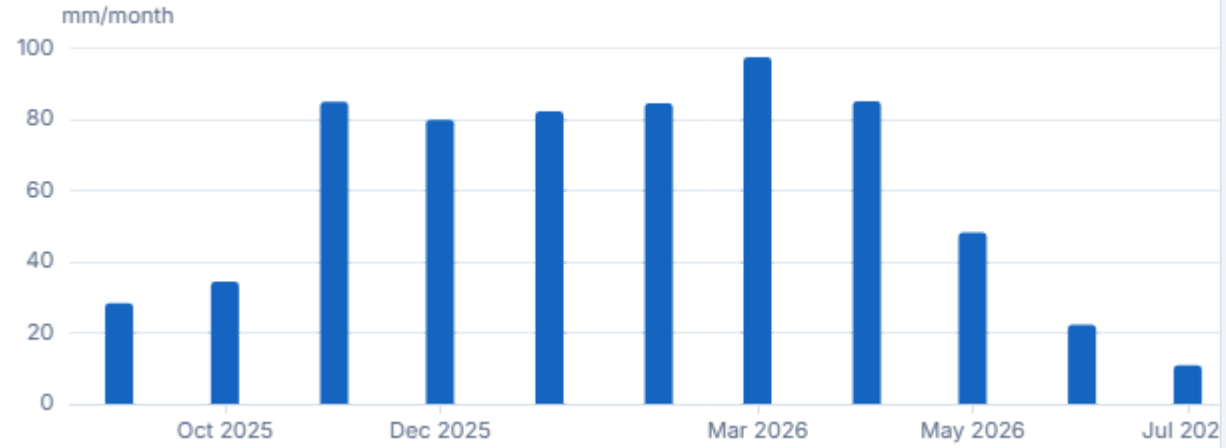
Daily Rainfall (mm/day) | PET (mm/day) | ET_0 (mm/day) | All | Reset



Meteorological Drought · Monthly Rainfall (mm/month) · §3.1

● Live · as of Aug 2026

Monthly Rainfall (mm/month)



Meteorological Drought · Seasonal Rainfall (mm/season) · §3.1

~~Seasonal Rainfall (mm/season)~~

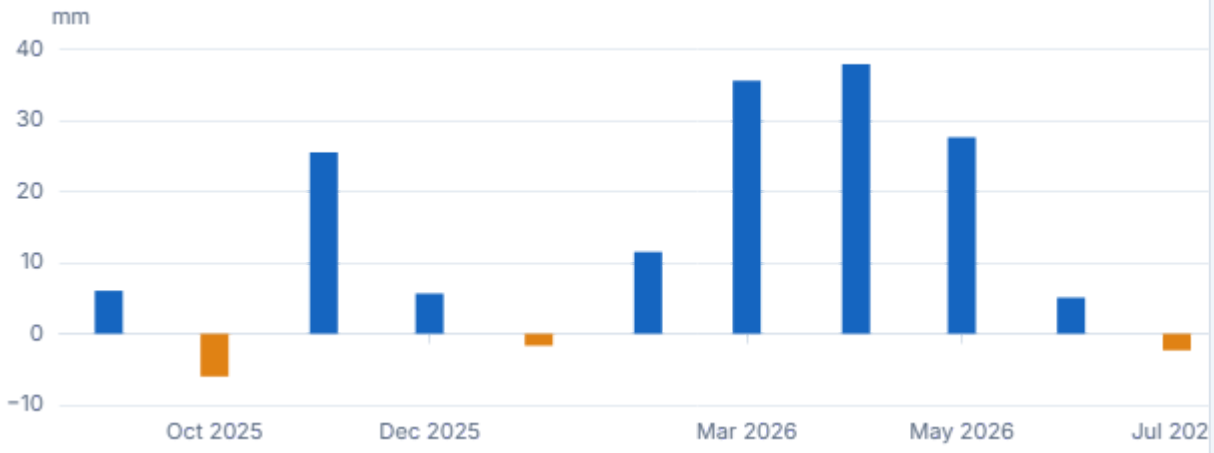
Not yet available

Withheld: Seasonal Rainfall (mm/season) (holds the calendar-year total, not a season: one value per district-year (Alfred Nzo 2014 = 825.67 mm = sum of its 12 monthly totals, 31 Dec missing))

Meteorological Drought · Rainfall Anomaly (mm) · §3.1

● Live · as of Aug 2026

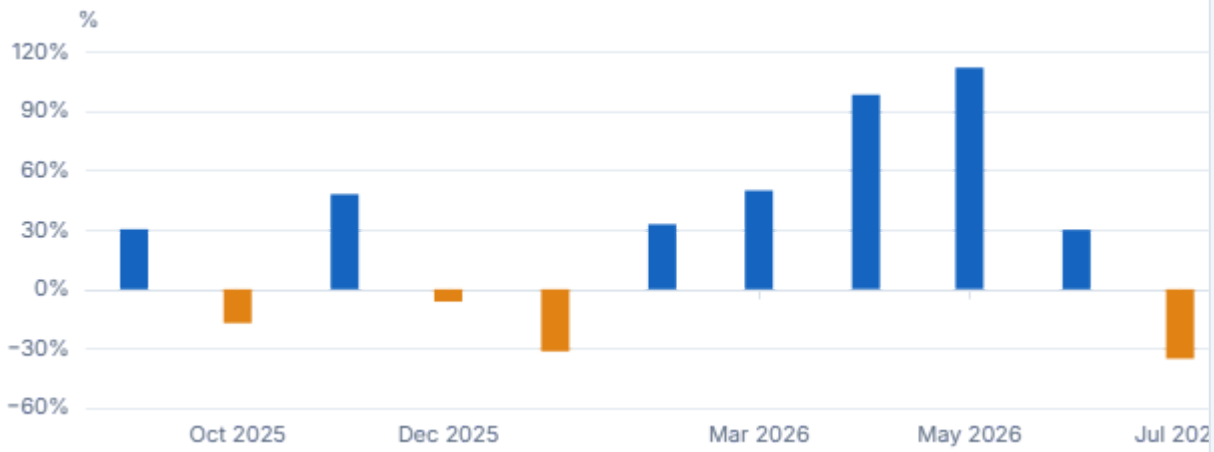
Rainfall Anomaly (mm)



Meteorological Drought · Rainfall Anomaly (%) · §3.1

● Live · as of Aug 2026

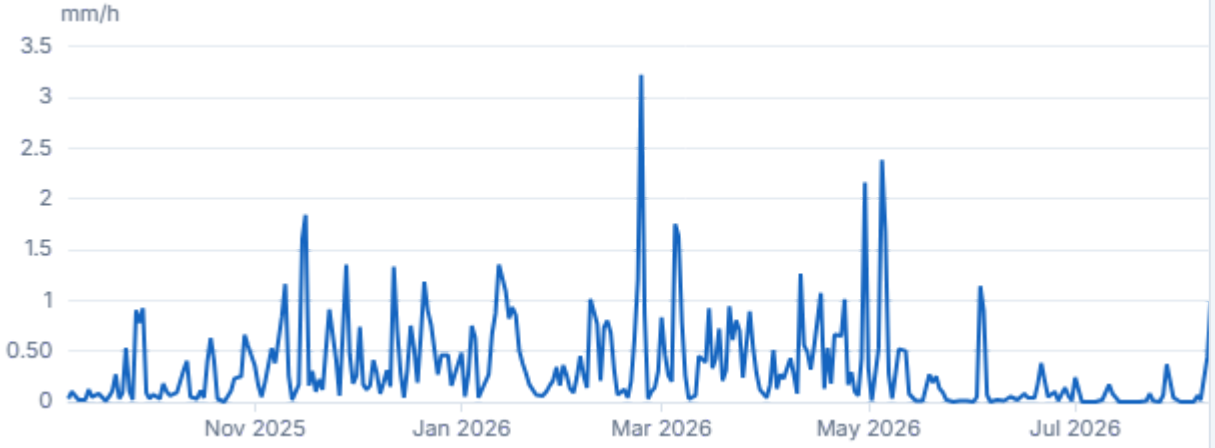
Rainfall Anomaly (%)



Meteorological Drought · Rainfall Intensity (mm/h) · §3.1

● Live · as of Sep 2026

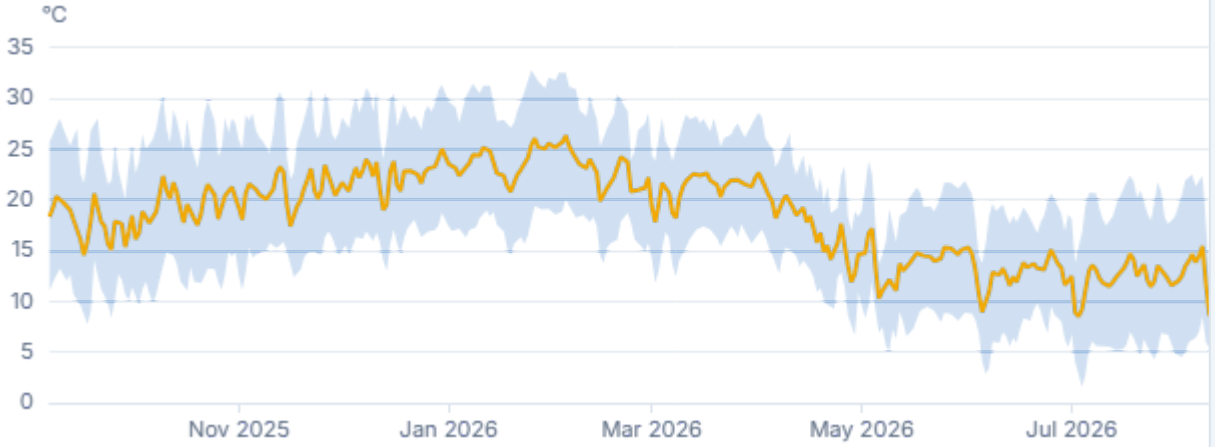
Rainfall Intensity (mm/h)



Meteorological Drought · Temperature (°C) · §3.1

● Live · as of Sep 2026

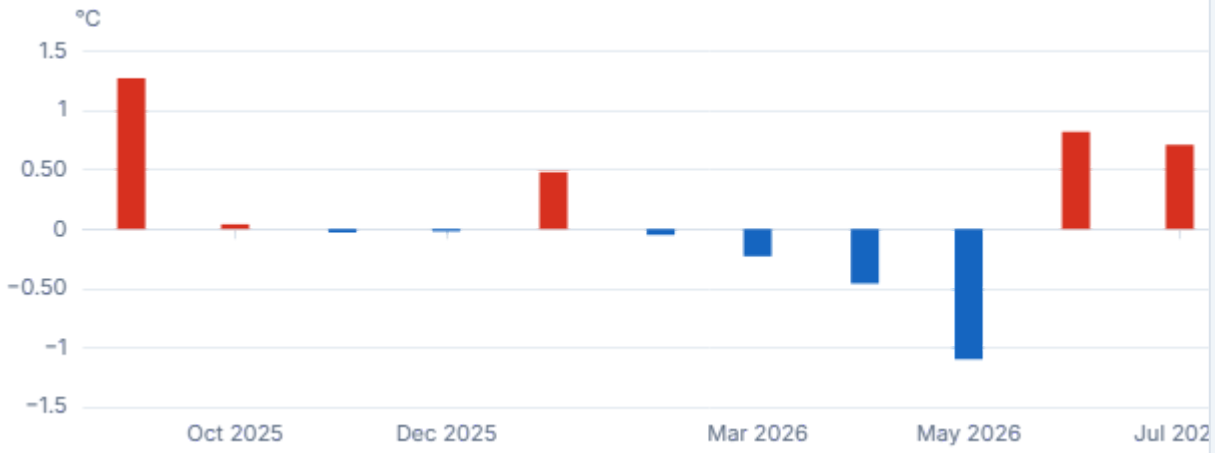
Tmin (°C) Tmax (°C) Tavg (°C) All Reset



Meteorological Drought · Temp Anomaly (°C) · §3.1

● Live · as of Aug 2026

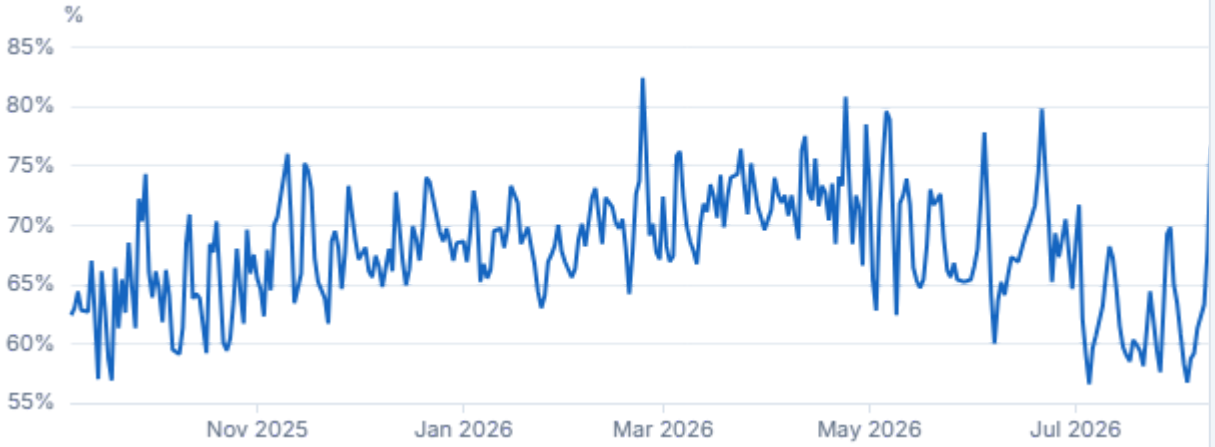
Temp Anomaly (°C)



Meteorological Drought · Relative Humidity (%) · §3.1

● Live · as of Sep 2026

Relative Humidity (%)



Meteorological Drought · Solar Radiation (W/m²) · §3.1

~~Solar Radiation (W/m²)~~

Not yet available

Withheld: Solar Radiation (W/m²) (synthetic: one value per calendar day (365 distinct values), identical in all 52 districts and every year; peaks in April (247 W/m²) with the minimum in Sep–Oct (113 W/m²), where the Southern-Hemisphere maximum is in December)

Meteorological Drought · Wind Speed 2m (m/s) · §3.1

~~Wind Speed 2m (m/s)~~

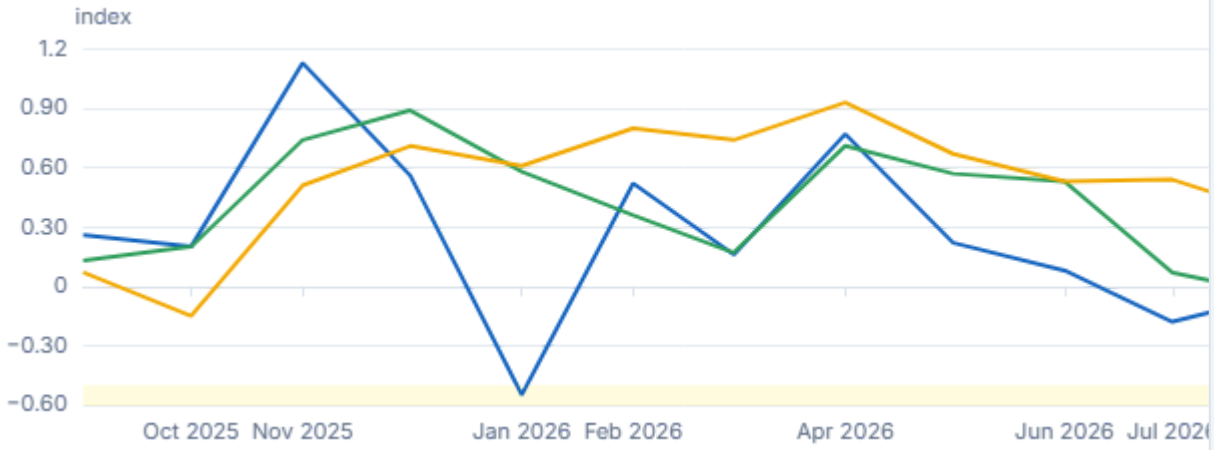
Not yet available

Withheld: Wind Speed 2m (m/s) (constant 2.5 m/s in every row)

Meteorological Drought · SPEI (index) · §3.1

● Live · as of Aug 2026

SPEI 1 | SPEI 3 | SPEI 6 | SPEI 12 | SPEI 24 | All | Reset



Also in the database: SPI 1 (identical to 6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master.SPI_1_Meteorological_Drought_Onset); SPI 3 (identical to 6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master.SPI_3_Short_Term_Agricultural_Drought); SPI 6 (identical to 6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master.SPI_6_Medium_Term_Hydrological_Impacts); SPI 12 (identical to 6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master.SPI_12_Long_Term_Groundwater_Impacts); SPI 24 (identical to 6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master.SPI_24_Very_Long_Term_Drought)

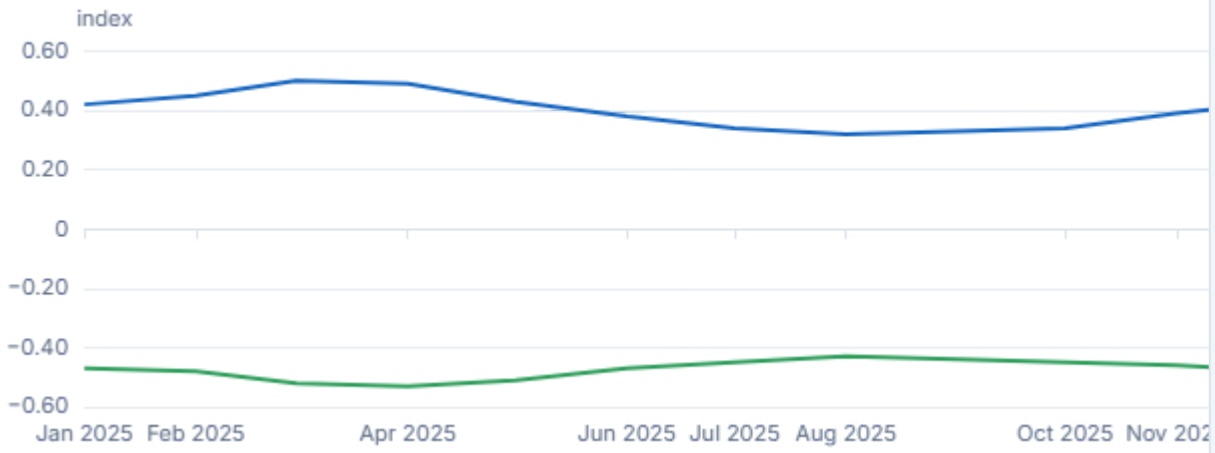
Satellite Remote Sensing §3.2 `satellite_remote_sensing` 9 live · 1 withheld · 0 duplicates

Data to Dec 2025

Satellite Remote Sensing · NDVI / NDWI (index) · §3.2

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

NDVI ● | NDWI ● | All | Reset



Satellite Remote Sensing · LST (°C) · §3.2

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

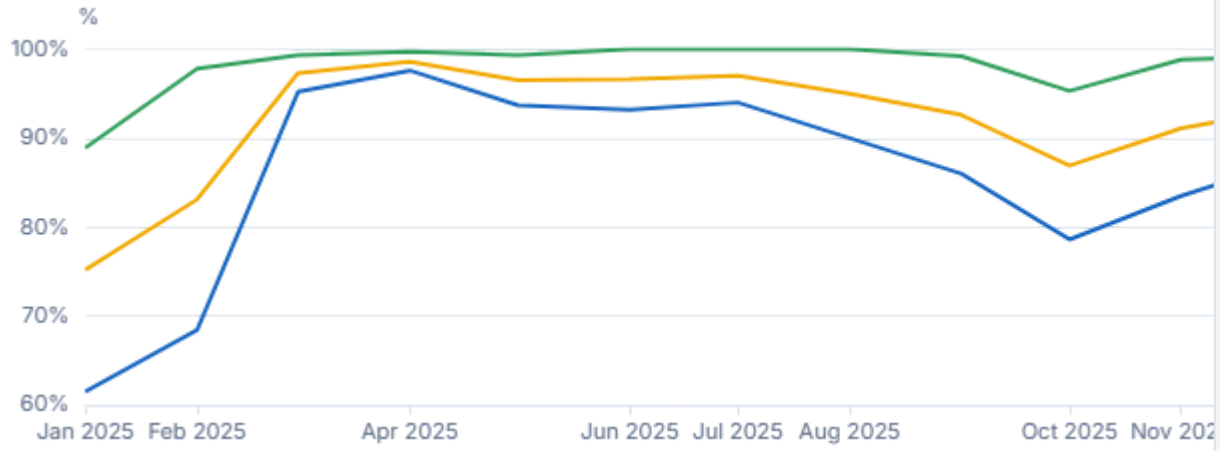
LST (°C) ●



Satellite Remote Sensing · VCI / TCI / VHI (%) · §3.2

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

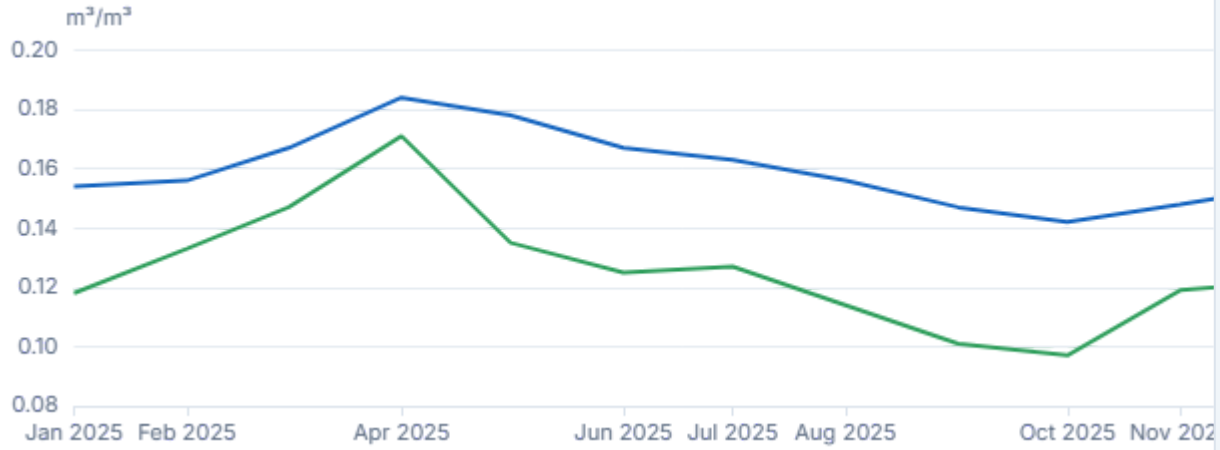
VCI (%) ● | TCI (%) ● | VHI (%) ● | All | Reset



Satellite Remote Sensing · Soil Moisture (m³/m³) · §3.2

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

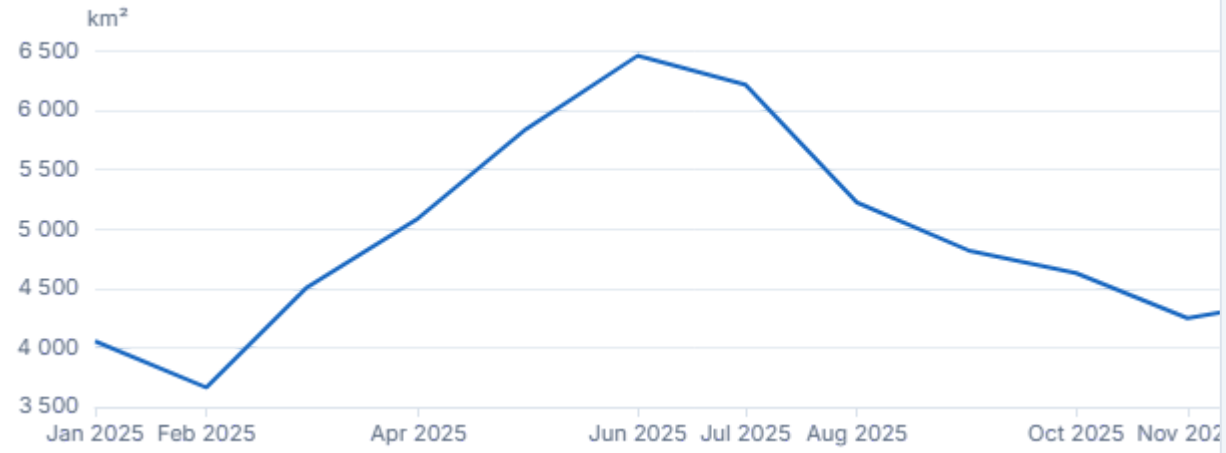
Rootzone Soil Moisture (m³/m³) ● | Surface Soil Moisture (m³/m³) ● | All | Reset



Satellite Remote Sensing · Surface Water Extent (km²) · §3.2

● Live · as of Dec 2025 | Data to Dec 2025

Surface Water Extent (km²) ●



Satellite Remote Sensing · GRACE TWS · §3.2

~~GRACE TWS~~

Not yet available

Withheld: GRACE TWS (values of 70–412 in 2001 and up to 270 in 2002, before GRACE data exist (launch March 2002); about ±10 from 2003; unit undocumented)

Hydrological Drought §3.3 `hydrological_drought_master` 1 live · 10 withheld · 0 duplicates

Data to Aug 2024

Hydrological Drought · River Discharge / FDC Percentiles / Surface Runoff / Baseflow Separation (m³/s) · §3.3

~~River Discharge (m³/s)~~ ~~FDC Percentiles (m³/s)~~ ~~Surface Runoff (m³/s)~~ ~~Baseflow Separation (m³/s)~~

Not yet available

Withheld: River Discharge (m³/s) (identical value in all 52 districts every month (placeholder)); FDC Percentiles (m³/s) (constant 0.01); Surface Runoff (m³/s) (identical value in all 52 districts every month (placeholder)); Baseflow Separation (m³/s) (identical value in all 52 districts every month (placeholder))

Hydrological Drought · SSI / SGI (index) · §3.3

Live

~~SSI~~ SGI

Data ends Aug 2024: nothing in the selected period.

Show last available 12 months (Sep 2023 – Aug 2024)

Hydrological Drought · Dam Storage (Mm³) · §3.3

~~Dam Storage (Mm³)~~

Not yet available

Withheld: Dam Storage (Mm³) (failed plausibility: frozen since Dec 2021 in all 52 districts (national 17 715 Mm³ every month) and implausible swings before (national 421 Mm³ in Jun 2021, 16 617 Mm³ in Aug 2021))

Hydrological Drought · Dam Level (% FSC) · §3.3

~~Dam Level (% FSC)~~

Not yet available

Withheld: Dam Level (% FSC) (failed plausibility: frozen since Dec 2021; 1 212 district-months at 0 % FSC (national mean 69 % in Jul 2002, 0.5 % in Jul 2003))

Hydrological Drought · Dam Inflow / Dam Outflow (m³/s) · §3.3

~~Dam Inflow (m³/s)~~ ~~Dam Outflow (m³/s)~~

Not yet available

Withheld: Dam Inflow (m³/s) (failed plausibility: inflow = outflow in 2 496 of 2 600 district-months since Nov 2021 (storage frozen)); Dam Outflow (m³/s) (failed plausibility: inflow = outflow in 2 496 of 2 600 district-months since Nov 2021 (storage frozen))

Hydrological Drought · Borehole Water Level (m bgl) · §3.3

~~Borehole Water Level (m bgl)~~

Not yet available

Withheld: Borehole Water Level (m bgl) (range −0.18…+0.20: not a depth below ground level)

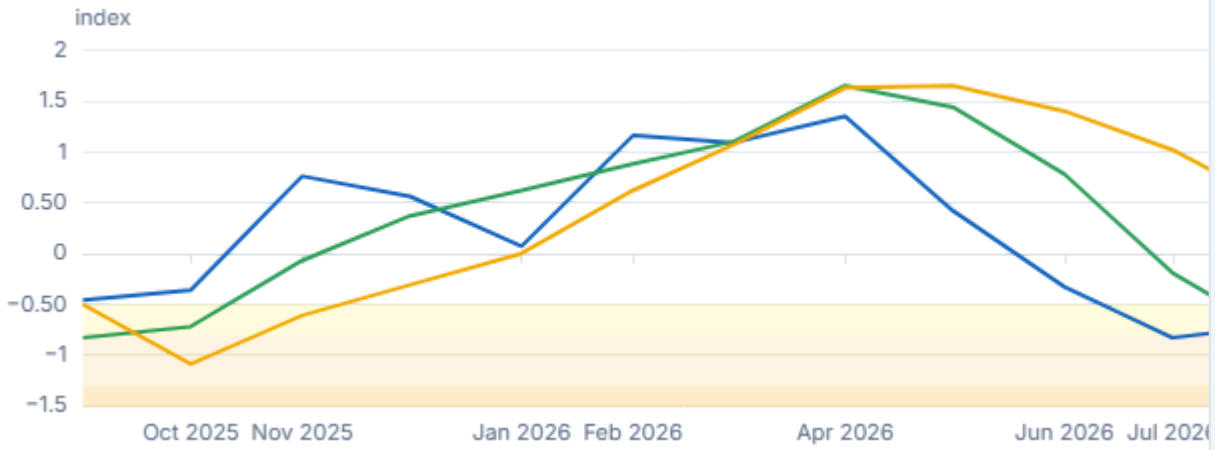
Rainfall Derived Drought Indices §6.2 `6.2_rainfall_derived_drought_indices_master`

6 live · 0 withheld · 2 duplicates data to Aug 2026

Rainfall Derived Drought Indices · SPI / RAI (index) · §6.2

● Live · as of Aug 2026

SPI 1 – Meteorological Drought Onset | SPI 3 – Short Term Agricultural Drought | SPI 6 – Medium Term Hydrological Impacts | SPI 12 – Long Term Groundwater Impacts | SPI 24 – Very Long Term Drought | RAI – Rainfall Anomaly Index | All | Reset



Also in the database: SPEI 3 – Agricultural Drought ET (identical to meteorological_drought_master.spei_3); SPEI 12 – Annual Water Balance Drought (identical to meteorological_drought_master.spei_12)

Drought Status Monitoring – Predictions & Forecasting

● Live · as of Aug 2026

SPI-3

−0.74

Forecast, 24 months · now −0.83

SPI-6

−0.46

Forecast, 24 months · now 0.44

SPEI-3

−0.03

Forecast, 24 months · now −0.05

Area in drought (D1–D4)

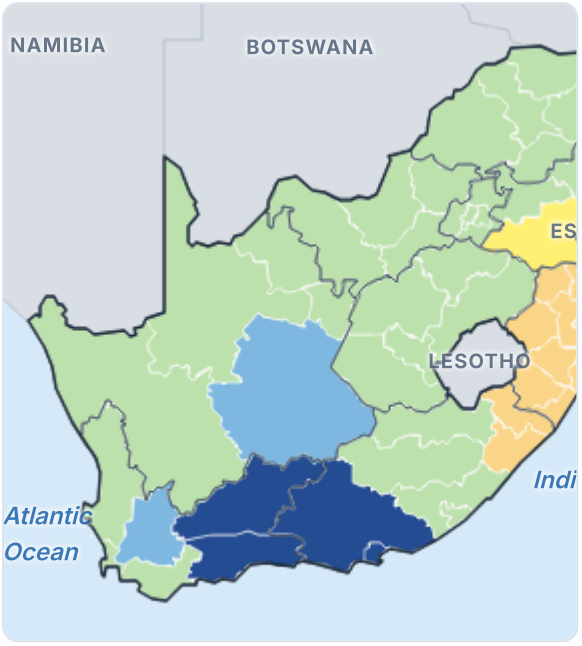
43.2%

Forecast, 24 months · now 8.5%

Current Drought Status (SPI-6, Latest)

Drought classification (SPI-6) – Aug 2026

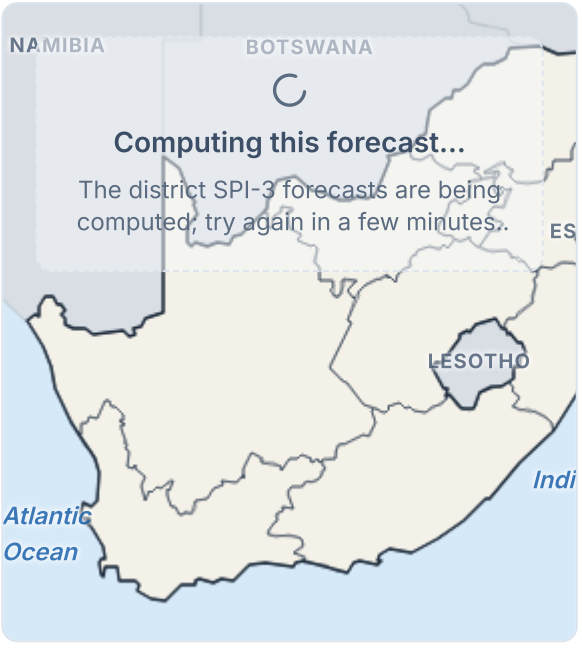
● Live · as of Aug 2026



- ≤ −2.0 D4 Exceptional Drought
- −2.0 to −1.6 D3 Extreme Drought
- −1.6 to −1.3 D2 Severe Drought
- −1.3 to −0.8 D1 Moderate Drought
- −0.8 to −0.5 D0 Abnormally Dry
- −0.5 to 1.0 Near normal
- 1.0 to 1.5 Moderately wet
- 1.5 to 2.0 Very wet
- ≥ 2.0 Extremely wet

Forecast Drought Status (SPI-3 Outlook)

outlook-1 | outlook-2 | **outlook-3** | forecast-

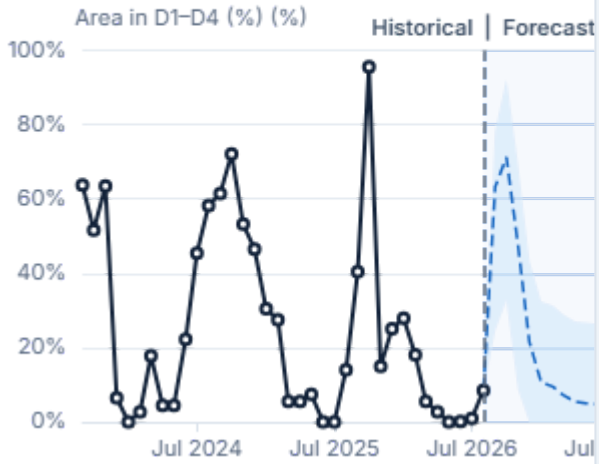


Drought Area Forecast (% of Area in D1–D4)

● Live · as of Aug 2026

South Africa | Western Cape | Eastern Cape

Uncertainty (10th–90th pct) Observed
Forecast (median)



Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Drought Severity Forecast (SPI-3)

● Live · as of Aug 2026

3 months | 6 months | 12 months | 24 montl

Uncertainty (10th–90th pct) Observed
Forecast (median)



Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026 · Open in Forecasting Studio

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Number of Drought-Affected Settlements (Forecast)

Not yet available

Settlement and population counts are not in the database, so drought impacts on them cannot be forecast

Population Affected by Drought (Forecast)

Not yet available

Settlement and population counts are not in the database, so drought impacts on them cannot be forecast

Key Drought Forecast Indicators

● Live · as of Aug 2026

Indicator	Unit	Current	3 months
SPI-3	—	−0.83	−0.20
SPI-6	—	0.44	−0.65
SPEI-3	—	−0.05	0.25
Area in drought (D1–D4)	%	8.5%	47.3%

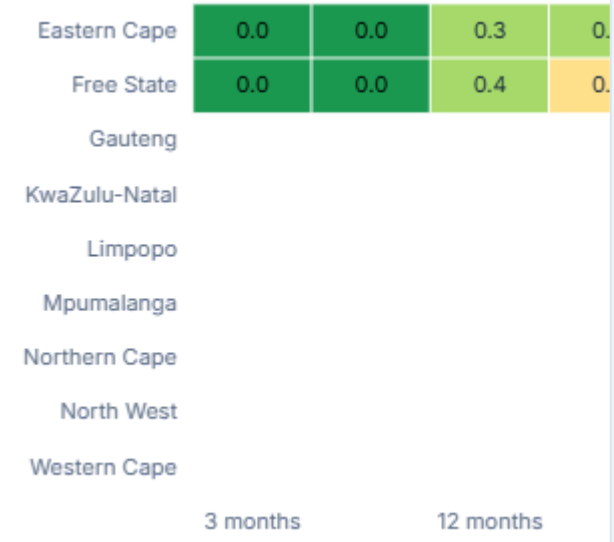
Scroll sideways for more columns →

Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) / SARIMA (order by AIC) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Probability of Severe Drought (D2+) – Province × Horizon

● Live · as of Aug 2026

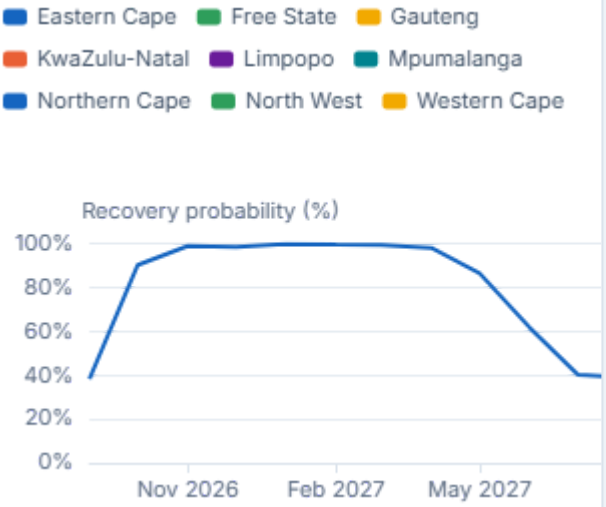


Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) / ETS / Holt-Winters · skill vs climatology −0.07 · data to Aug 2026

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Drought Recovery Probability (Next 12 Months)

● Live · as of Aug 2026

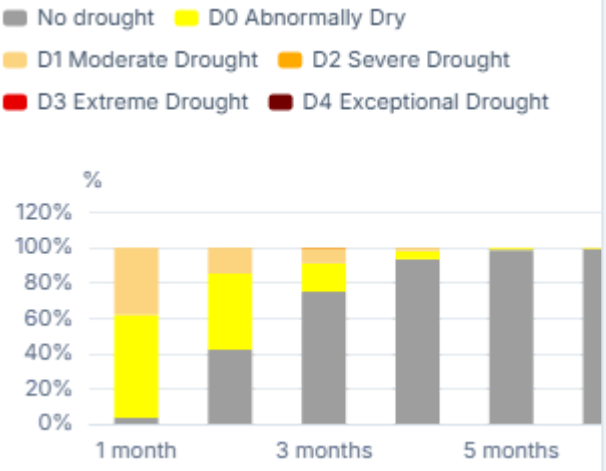


Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Drought Class Probability by Lead Time

● Live · as of Aug 2026



Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026 · Open in Forecasting Studio

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Drought Recovery Outlook

● Live · as of Aug 2026

Time frame	Expected conditions	Recovery probabili
3 months (Nov 2026)	No drought	91%
6 months (Feb 2027)	No drought	100%
12 months (Aug 2027)	D0 Abnormally Dry	54%
24 months (Aug 2028)	D0 Abnormally Dry	53%

Statistical forecast · Climatology (same-month mean) · skill vs climatology 0.00 · data to Aug 2026 · Open in Forecasting Studio

⚠ This model does not beat the long-term average for this variable.

Drought-Affected Settlements

Sample

Drought-Affected Settlements
of 1 254 monitored

973

↘ −7.2%

vs last year

Sample

Population Affected

3 979 878 people

Sample

High-Vulnerability Settlements
Vulnerability index ≥ 0.65

445

Sample

Water Supply Reliability

76 %

Sample

Alternative Supply Coverage
Of affected settlements

63 %

Sample

Drought Exposure Index
0 = none, 1 = extreme

0.53

Sample

Active Interventions
Tankering, boreholes, storage

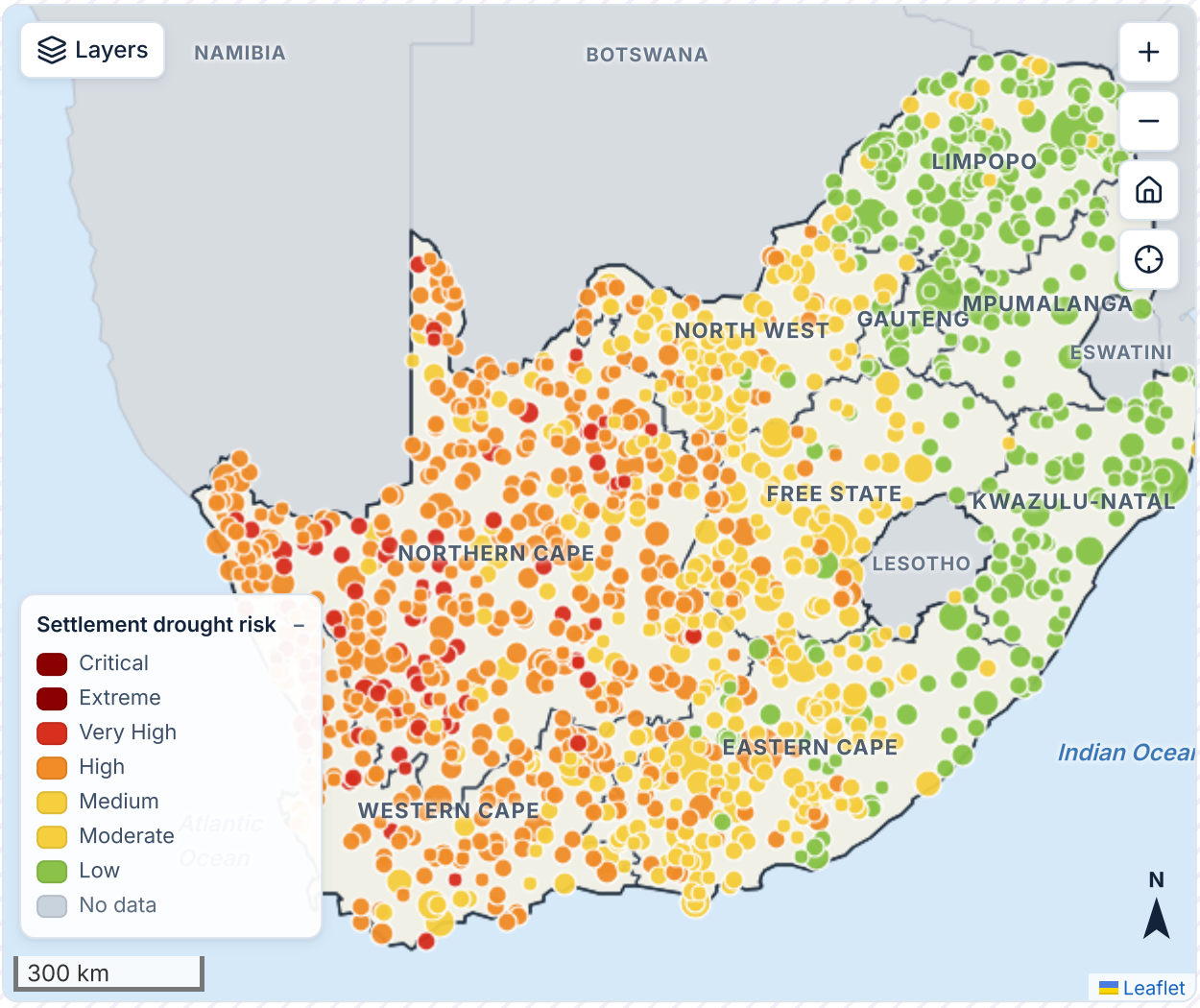
582 settlements

Sample

Drought-Affected Settlements (Current Conditions)

Sample

Drought-affected settlements (risk) | Drought exposure | Water supply reliability | Intervention status



Top 10 Drought-Affected Settlements (Current)

Sample

#	Settlement	Municipality	Prov.	Population	Risk	Supply status
1	Karoo Hoogland informal area 29	Karoo Hoogland	NC	2 795	Very High	Restricted
2	Nama Khoi farm community 16	Nama Khoi	NC	4 002	Very High	Restricted
3	Siyathemba farm community 10	Siyathemba	NC	1 873	Very High	Restricted
4	Khâi-Ma village cluster 1	Khâi-Ma	NC	2 624	Very High	Restricted
5	Hantam informal area 38	Hantam	NC	6 499	Very High	Restricted
6	Kamiesberg farm community 11	Kamiesberg	NC	1 014	Very High	Restricted
7	Matzikama village cluster 1	Matzikama	WC	2 057	Very High	Restricted
8	Hantam village cluster 7	Hantam	NC	3 986	Very High	Restricted
9	Khâi-Ma village cluster 11	Khâi-Ma	NC	4 443	Very High	Restricted

Settlement Severity Distribution

Sample



Very high	84 settlements	7%
High	498 settlements	40%
Moderate	391 settlements	31%
Low / no risk	281 settlements	22%

Population Affected by Severity

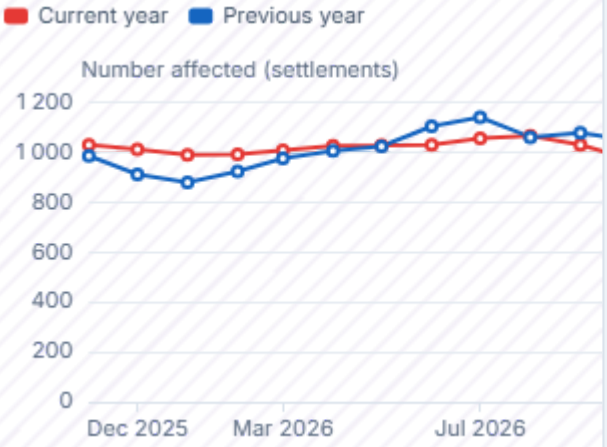
Sample



Very high	0.246 people	5%
High	2.02 people	39%
Moderate	1.72 people	33%
Low / no risk	1.25 people	24%

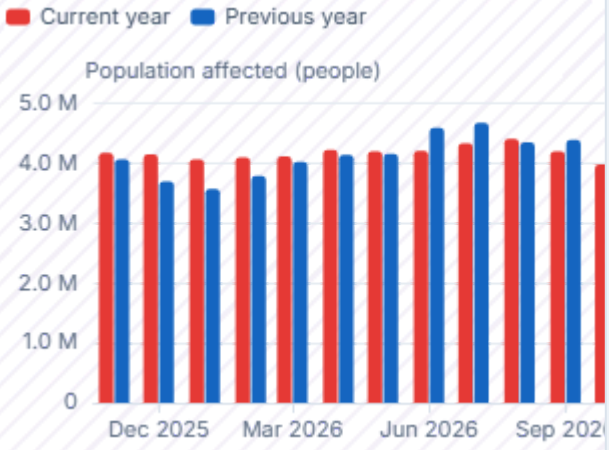
Number of Drought-Affected Settlements (Trend)

Sample



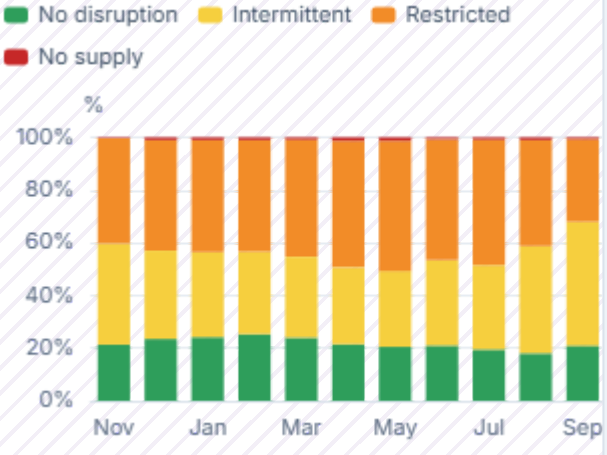
Population Affected (Trend)

Sample



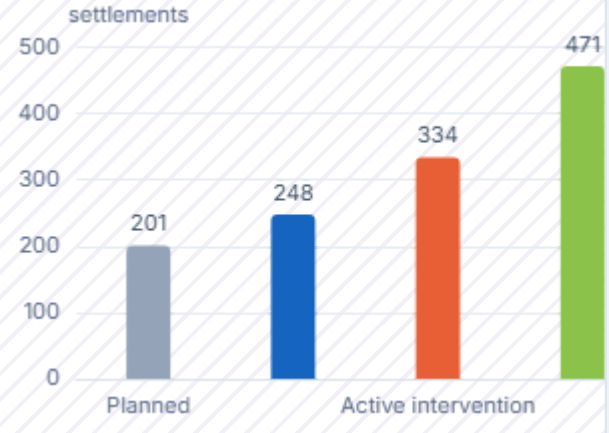
Water Supply Status of Monitored Settlements

Sample



Intervention Status (Number of Settlements)

Sample



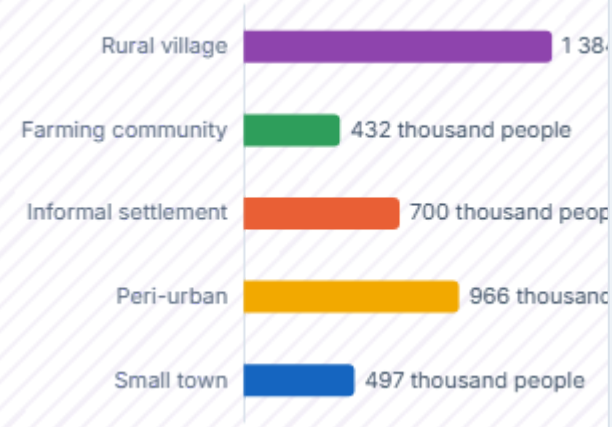
Settlements by Province (by Risk)

Sample



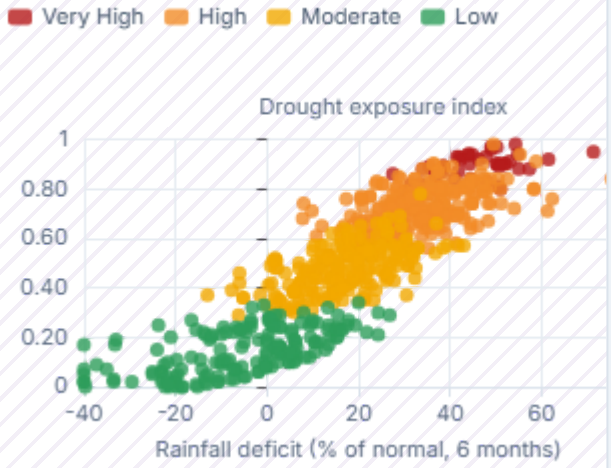
Population Affected by Settlement Type

Sample



Drought Exposure vs Rainfall Deficit

Sample



Alternative Supply Sources

Sample

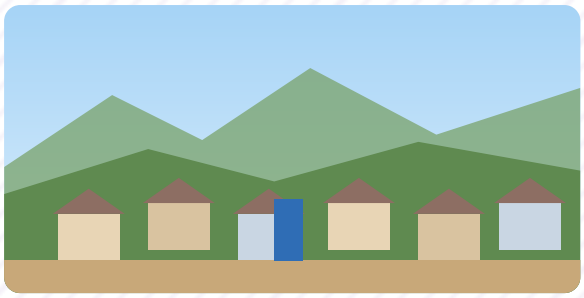


Water tankers	**313 settlements**	32%
Emergency boreholes	**259 settlements**	27%
Storage tanks (JoJo)	**167 settlements**	17%
Spring protection / rainwater	**94 settlements**	10%
None yet	**140 settlements**	14%

Settlement Information (Selected)

Karoo Hoogland informal area 29 (Northern Cape)

Sample



Status	Very High
Settlement type	Informal settlement
Municipality	Karoo Hoogland
Province	Northern Cape
Population / households	2 795 / 767
Primary water source	River abstraction
SPI-6 / drought class	-2.62 (D4)
Vegetation condition (VCI)	0%
Nearest dams (storage)	6% FSC
Groundwater (SGI)	−1.85
Drought exposure index	0.98
Vulnerability index	0.95
Poverty index	95
Water access backlog	48% of households
Supply reliability	54%
Response status	Intervention
Tanker days (last 12 months)	144
Data sources	Stats SA, DWS, SAWS, SANSA, municipalities

Water Infrastructure Condition (Affected)

Sample



Top 5 by Population Affected

Sample

#	Settlement	Municipality	Prov.
1	Graaff-Reinet (Umasizakhe)	Dr Beyers Naude	EC
2	Cradock (Lingelihle)	Inxuba Yethemba	EC
3	Thaba Nchu (Selosesha)	Mangaung	FS
4	Botshabelo (Section T)	Mangaung	FS
5	Wepener	Mangaung	FS

Scroll sideways for more columns →